3.1 Preparing to Fight

King George had reached his limit. He believed the colonies were out of control and had to be reined in. Maybe the king didn't understand that the colonists had reached their limits, too. Could there be a war on the horizon?

MAIN IDEA Britain enacted a series of laws to punish Boston and force the colonies into obedience, but the colonies united to resist the laws.

INTOLERABLE LAWS

Parliament decided to punish the Bostonians. It passed a series of laws called the Coercive Acts. In the colonies, these laws quickly became known as the **Intolerable Acts**.

The Intolerable Acts prevented Massachusetts from governing itself. The Massachusetts Assembly would no longer be made up of representatives elected by the people of the colony. Instead, it was to be replaced by a ruling council of officials appointed by the king. The Quartering Act was strengthened. Now, if no barracks were available, troops could take over private homes. In addition, the port of Boston would be closed until the residents could pay for the tea they had destroyed.

The British government expected the new laws to isolate Boston and convince the other colonies to be obedient. Instead, towns near Boston sent much-needed supplies to the city and took in Bostonians looking for work. Other colonies called for a meeting to decide on a united response to the Intolerable Acts. According to the Virginia House of Burgesses, "an attack made on one of our sister colonies . . . is an attack made on all British America."



Patrick Henry
Patrick Henry was known for crafting speeches on the spot with no notes. In one of his most famous speeches, given on March 23, 1775, Henry ended with the now-famous phrase, "Give me liberty or give me death!"

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AMERICAN PLACES

Carpenters' Hall Philadelphia

Books were hard to find in the 1700s, so in 1731, Benjamin Franklin established the Library Company of Philadelphia, America's first lending library. For the first time, the public had access to a collection of books that could be borrowed and shared. In September 1773, the library moved to Carpenters' Hall (left).

Members of both Continental Congresses used the library, making it the first unofficial Library of Congress. Officers of the British Army were also permitted to borrow books, provided that they returned them in good condition.

SEEDS OF WAR

The meeting of the colonies—called the **First Continental Congress**—took place in Philadelphia on September 5, 1774. Every colony except Georgia sent delegates. The 56 representatives included Patrick Henry, Samuel and John Adams, and George Washington. The main purpose of the First Continental Congress was to discuss ways to have the Intolerable Acts repealed.

The delegates wanted to assert the rights of the 13 British colonies in North America. One of the resolutions they passed stated that the Intolerable Acts were "gross infractions of those rights to which we are justly entitled by the laws of nature, the British constitution, and the charter of this province." However, the First Continental Congress was not ready to declare independence. In the end, the delegates simply voted to end all trade with Britain and Ireland—still a significant step.

Several delegates believed it was also time to start training for a possible fight with Britain. One of the other resolutions stated that everyone qualified to fight should learn "the art of war as soon as possible." Some delegates may have believed that if there was any fighting, it would be over quickly. But others, like Patrick Henry, expected all-out war.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the colonies react to the Intolerable Acts?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** What might learning "the art of war" have meant to colonists?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What were the Intolerable Acts, and how did they backfire on the British government?

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